Aron Take-Home: Procurement Agent

Context

Aron is building a chief of staff for procurement teams. Something that carries the work, rather than answering questions about it.

Most of a buyer's day is reconciliation. Suppliers answer an RFQ however they feel like, the answers don't line up, and a lot of what matters isn't in them at all.

This exercise is a small version of that job. How you scope it matters more to us than how much you finish.

The task

A buyer has an RFQ out for a machined aluminium bracket, part **BRK-4471-A**, 60,000 units a year. Four suppliers have replied. The replies are free text and no two are laid out the same way. The packet is in the appendix.

Build an agent that takes the packet and gets the buyer somewhere useful.

We haven't said what useful means, what to do about what the packet doesn't tell you, or where to stop. That's yours to decide.

Scope

Plan for two to three hours. There's more here than fits in that.

Keep whatever pieces you want light. The thing that matters is telling us where you chose to go deep and why.

If you run out of time, write up what you'd do next.

What to send us

A repo, as a GitHub link or a zip, with:

The code, with a README that tells us how to run it. Include where to put an API key if it needs one.

A DECISIONS.md, a short video walking us through it, or both. What you built, what you cut, and why. Where it falls over. What you'd do next with another day. A page or five minutes is plenty.

Your AI transcripts. The full sessions, unedited, plus whatever the agent produced when you ran it.

Ground rules

- Spend at most three hours on this. If you feel like you're going over, hand in what you have.
- Use any model, stack or library you want, and use AI as much as you need to.
- If something's unclear, email us, or make the call yourself and note it.
- Send it back within a week. If you need longer, just say.
- We'll then spend 45 minutes going through it with you.

What we're looking at

Mostly your decision-making inside the time box: a mix of architecture, product judgment, and what you chose to leave out. We'll go through it on the call.

Appendix: the quote packet

The four quotes below are a starting point. Make up more of your own if you want them.

Quote 1 — Tri-State Metalcraft

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From: dmorrow@tristatemetalcraft.com
Subject: RE: RFQ BRK-4471-A

Hi Karen,

Good talking Tuesday. Here's where we land on the bracket:

$4.85 per piece, FOB our dock in Cleveland. That's at your 60k annual
number -- we'd hold that price for releases of 5,000 or more, below that
we'd have to look at it again.

Tooling is $6,200, one time, invoiced on PO.

Lead time 4 weeks from release, and we can usually beat that. Net 30.

Pricing firm for 90 days. Anodizing is done in house so we're not exposed
on that the way some of the overseas guys are.

Dan
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Quote 2 — Nordkant Prazisionsteile GmbH

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NORDKANT PRAZISIONSTEILE GMBH
Quotation No. NK-2026-1184

Part: BRK-4471-A (per customer drawing rev C)

Price schedule, annual volume:
   20,000 pcs    EUR 4.30 / pc
   60,000 pcs    EUR 3.92 / pc
  100,000 pcs    EUR 3.71 / pc

Delivery: DDP Columbus, Ohio
Lead time: 11 weeks from order release
Payment: Net 60 days. 2% discount for payment within 10 days.
Tooling: included, amortized over first 40,000 pcs
Packaging: returnable steel containers, deposit EUR 2,800 (refundable)

Validity: 30 days from date of issue.
Prices subject to quarterly adjustment per LME aluminium index,
base 2026 Q1. Adjustments applied where index moves more than 4%.
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Quote 3 — Pacific Rim Components

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PART NO          BRK-4471-A
UNIT PRICE       USD 3,240.00 / 1,000 PCS
MOQ              25,000 PCS
TERMS            FOB KAOHSIUNG
LEAD TIME        9 WEEKS PRODUCTION
SHIPPING         5 WEEKS OCEAN
TOOLING          USD 4,800.00
PAYMENT          30% T/T DEPOSIT, 70% BEFORE SHIPMENT
NOTES            PRICE BASED ON DRAWING REV B
                 ANODIZING SUBCONTRACTED
                 FREIGHT AND DUTY NOT INCLUDED
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Quote 4 — Brightwater Precision

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From: l.vega@brightwaterprecision.mx
Subject: BRK-4471-A

Karen,

We can do this part. Looking at around $4.40 a piece at your volumes,
EXW Queretaro. Lead time 6-8 weeks once we're running.

Tooling we'd need to confirm after our engineering team reviews the
drawing -- I don't want to quote you a number and then change it.

One thing worth mentioning: we'd carry four weeks of safety stock for
you at our facility at no charge, which I know has been an issue for you
with the Asia suppliers.

Happy to get on a call this week.

Luis
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